

See also: The Geneva Conventions 152–155 ■ The Hague Conventions 174–177 ■ The United Nations and International Court of Justice 212–219 ■ The Partial Test Ban Treaty 244–247 ■ The Anti-Personnel Mine Ban Convention 288–289



of chemical weapons, although not their manufacture. Japan used them widely against the Chinese during the Sino-Japanese War of 1937–1945. At the start of World War II, both Nazi Germany and the Allies had stockpiles, though they were rarely used on the battlefield, chiefly for fear of retaliation.

International agreements

In 1975, after several years of preparatory work, the Biological Weapons Convention came into force. This was the first multilateral disarmament treaty to ban the

A victim of a chemical weapons attack in Syria in April 2017. Syrian president Bashar al-Assad blamed “terrorists” for this and other attacks, but his armed forces were implicated.

production of an entire category of weapons, but its effectiveness was limited by the absence of the means to verify compliance.

Real progress came only with the thawing of US–Soviet relations after 1985. By 1990, both countries had agreed to halt production and destroy existing chemical weapons, paving the way for the global agreement that followed in 1993.

Provisions and abuses

The CWC’s provisions were clear: every signatory agreed to produce no further chemical weapons, eliminate any they already held, and allow mandatory inspections by the Organisation for the Prohibition of Chemical Weapons (OPCW), carried out if necessary with only 12 hours’ notice. In 2007, Albania became the first country to comply fully, and by late 2018, 97 percent

“The use in war of asphyxiating, poisonous or other gases, and of all analogous liquids, materials or devices, has been justly condemned.
Geneva Protocol, 1925

of the stockpiles declared by their possessor states had been verifiably destroyed. Implementation of the ban has been hard to police, however. Syria signed up for the CWC in 2013 and claimed to have destroyed all its chemical weapons, but repeated attacks with chemical weapons have been reported in the civil war that erupted that year. Despite denials, Syrian state forces have been strongly implicated. ■

Iraq’s chemical weapons

Born in c. 1941, Ali Hassan al-Majid (better known as “Chemical Ali”) was a cousin of the Iraqi dictator Saddam Hussein. He held some of the most important government posts during the 1980s and 1990s, and during the later stages of the Iran–Iraq War (1980–1988), he commanded all the state agencies in the Kurdish-populated north of the country.

Iraq had deployed chemical weapons against Iranian forces since 1980, but in 1987–1988, al-Majid authorized their use

against Kurdish civilians. The Al-Anfal (“Spoils of War”) genocide against the Kurds may have resulted in as many as 180,000 deaths. In the most notorious incident, on March 16, 1988, Iraqi planes dropped mustard gas and sarin canisters on the town of Halabja, killing at least 5,000 and inflicting injury and long-term illness on thousands more. Chemical Ali was arrested by US forces in 2003 and, after a lengthy trial, was executed in 2010.



Ali Hassan al-Majid ordered the use of deadly chemical weapons against Kurdish civilians in northern Iraq in 1987–1988.